

often will respond to a request for a favor—but it is truer that they will respond when that favor will in some way benefit themselves or, in any event, benefit some third party or parties who seem worthy of such benefit.

Thus, if I were selling scuff-proof shoes (if there is such a shoe) by mail, I might send you a letter asking you to do me a favor by wearing a pair of my shoes for ten days and seeing if you could scuff them. You would do this at my risk—but you would see that if you wore them for ten days and could not scuff them, you would have done *yourself* a favor in discovering such wonderful shoes. Or, writing to a parent, I might ask him to do me a favor by taking the X Encyclopedia into his home for thirty days and seeing the wonderful effect on his children's marks in school . . . wherein the favor actually is done for a third party.

Now look at the closing paragraph of the first letter. What implication lies in: "Thanking you in advance for any consideration you may care to show me"? There is a strong undertone to the effect that the writer anticipates refusal! Well, why not refuse? This writer has advanced little reason for a busy man to take the trouble to write a letter. The recipient did read that those who purchased the book would welcome an opportunity, and so forth, but that hardly hits home, and it is buried in the body of the letter.

The entire letter reminds me of a salesman who once wanted me to subscribe to the *Saturday Evening Post*. He held up a copy of the magazine and said: "You wouldn't subscribe to the *Post* to help me out, would you?"

Well, I am the one who wrote the first letter. At least give me credit for having later improved it!

Now look at the second letter. Notice that the first paragraph asks a question—and the question can be answered in only one way. The question, moreover, is asked in such a way as to set up an entire viewpoint toward the matter at hand.

The reader is now conditioned. The second paragraph carries him along. It mentions me and my affairs briefly, but it is mostly taken up with a statement of fact that will make him nod his head and know I am talking his language. Even if he never has thought in terms of cause and effect, as regards pay envelopes, he will see the point as being clear and helpful.

The next paragraph might be said to contain flattery—or it might be said to contain nothing but the truth. The men to whom I wrote had truthfully come up from the bottom to en-